The Effect of Cultural Taste Breadth on Formal and Informal Connectivity: A Longitudinal Investigation*

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Abstract

Does cultural taste primarily flow from shifting social networks, or do durable cultural tastes help stabilize personal communities over time? Network transmission models posit that tastes are volatile and decay when social ties are disrupted, whereas cultural capital models posit that tastes are enduring dispositions that facilitate tie maintenance. Using longitudinal panel data from the Project Canada Survey (1985–1995), I adjudicate between these frameworks via Mundlak (within-between) mixed-effects models. I find that holding durable cultural breadth (omnivore tastes) longitudinally predicts higher rates of maintained social connectivity, operating strongly for "elective" ties (friends) while also significantly aiding structurally "prescribed" ties (family). Furthermore, within-person temporary expansions in cultural repertoires yield immediate boosts to informal socializing with both friends and family, but not to formal organizational integration. These findings point toward a decisive advantage for the cultural capital model: tastes act as durable, selective filters that maintain voluntary social ties, while remaining highly resilient to network shocks.

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1 Introduction

Structural models of taste formation, transmission, and decay in the sociology of culture posit that current tastes are largely a product of the individual's current network configuration (Mark, 1998, 2003). The standard assumption is that tastes are transmitted through existing network ties, in particular those social connections characterized by sociodemographic similarity (Lazarsfeld and Merton, 1954; McPherson and Cook, 2001). From this perspective, tastes are not enduring aspects of the person but malleable, "thin" contents liable to change when network ties change (Mark, 1998). Given that personal networks are highly volatile and exhibit great rates of turnover over time—particularly as driven by major life-course transitions like marriage, childbirth, changing jobs, or geographical mobility (Hollstein, 2023; Marsden, 2024; Vacchiano et al., 2024; Lin and Marin, 2022; Weiss et al., 2022; Burt, 2000; Suitor and Morgan, 1997)—this network perspective implies that cultural tastes should exhibit even greater rates of instability over time (Lizardo, 2006).

In contrast, the cultural capital model (Bourdieu, 1984; Holt, 1998) conceives of cultural tastes as highly durable dispositions. Formed early in life, these embodied cultural practices are resistant to change and serve as stable resources to maintain and forge network connections (Lizardo, 2006). Recent empirical work strongly supports this "cultured means connected" hypothesis, demonstrating that cultural tastes not only improve the quality and stability of network ties through shared activities and "cultural talk" (Jæger and Meuleman, 2026; Meuleman and Jæger, 2023; Lizardo, 2016), but also serve as structural opportunities for positive social exchange that generate relational cohesion (Vanzella-Yang and Abrutyn, 2022; Hachen et al., 2022). Furthermore, holding diverse or highbrow tastes is positively linked to accessing higher socioeconomic resources within those networks (Meuleman, 2021). Rather than being at the mercy of shifting networks, stable cultural tastes may act as a reciprocal driver of network maintenance, enabling individuals to sustain interaction across constantly shifting personal communities.

This research note empirically adjudicates between these divergent expectations using longitudinal panel data. Specifically, I address the following research questions: (1) Does a broad, stable repertoire of cultural tastes (cultural capital) longitudinally predict the maintenance of social connectivity, independent of reciprocal effects? (2) Does cultural capital specifically buffer "Elective" ties (friends) rather than structurally prescribed ties (family and kin)? (3) Do temporary, within-person spikes in cultural engagement yield immediate gains in connectivity?

By leveraging the Project Canada Survey (1985–1995) and employing modern panel data estimators (Mundlak within-between mixed-effects models), this note provides a direct test of the cultural capital versus network transmission frameworks.

2 Data and variables

The data for this study come from the *Project Canada Survey* (PCS). The PCS is a longitudinal study of the social attitudes and cultural practices of a representative sample of Canadian citizens extending from 1975–1995, conducted out of the University of Lethbridge. The project began data collection in 1975 with a total 1,917 respondents. Every five years since representative samples of similar size have been collected, with a "core" set of respondents that have participated in previous surveys. While the PCS began in 1975, I exclude the 1975 and 1980 waves from the primary event-history models because the detailed items capturing cultural consumption and specific network interaction frequencies were not introduced or consistently coded until the mid-1980s. Because it collected data on cultural practices and patterns of social interaction and membership in important foci of social interaction (i.e., voluntary association memberships) over time for the same individuals, the PCS panel spanning 1985–1995 provides an excellent opportunity to deal with issues of causal order in the relationship between cultural taste dynamics and life-course events associated with network turnover. In the following study, I use the longitudinal panel covering the core years of 1985, 1990, and 1995, focusing on the core set of respondents who participated across these waves.

Data Processing and Limitations. The PCS data provide a rare look at longitudinal cultural tastes, but require harmonization due to survey design changes across waves. First, later waves shifted to 5-point and 7-point frequency scales; these were harmonized back to the original 4-point scale (1 = Very often, 4 = Never). Finally, the raw "frequency of interaction with friends" indicator was reverse-coded (where 1 equaled "Many" and 3 equaled "Few"); this was recoded prior to estimation so that higher integer values correctly reflect greater social connectivity in the ordinal models. There are also no direct ego-network size measures, so interaction frequency and voluntary memberships serve as proxies for sociability.

2.1 Variables

2.1.1 Cultural Taste breadth indicators

To assess the hypotheses connected to the effects of cultural taste on indicators of sociability and social connectivity, I created a cultural taste breadth variable for the 1985, 1990, and 1995 waves. This is a simple additive index indicating participation in a wide range of cultural activities. Using the same set of items, the respondent receives one point in the cultural taste breadth scale if he or she reports engaging in the following cultural practices either "very often" or "sometimes": (1) listening to music, (2) going to a movie, (3) going to a play/theatric performance, (4) attending a sports event, (5) watching videos, (6) engaging in a hobby, (7) reading magazines, (8) following sports, (9) reading books, and (10) reading a newspaper. This index ranges from 0 to 10 and is constructed by summing binary indicators for each activity where the respondent's participation frequency corresponds to “very often” or “sometimes.”

2.1.2 Social connectedness indicators

In order to test the cultural capital hypotheses, I use three indicators of social connectivity: (a) the frequency of informal interaction with close friends, (b) the frequency of interaction with family members (kin), and (c) the ability to remain connected to important foci for social interaction, such as voluntary associations.

The indicators for frequency of interaction with close friends and family members rely on questions that were asked across the 1985, 1990, and 1995 waves, though the exact response categories varied over time. In 1985, respondents were asked to choose among four options: “Very often”, “Sometimes”, “Seldom”, or “Never”. In 1990, the scale shifted to a frequency format: “Very often”, “Sometimes”, “Seldom”, “Monthly”, and “Hardly ever or never”. In 1995, a 7-point scale was used: “Daily”, “Several times a week”, “About once a week”, “2-3 times a month”, “About once a month”, “Hardly ever”, and “Never”. To harmonize these across the panel while respecting the ordinal nature of the underlying construct, the responses for both friends and family were collapsed into a consistent three-category ordinal scale: (1) “Seldom/Never”, (2) “Sometimes”, and (3) “Very Often”.

Retention of connections to important interaction foci is measured using a scale that simply counts the distinct types of voluntary associations the respondent belongs to in each wave of the survey: these include private clubs, sport clubs, service organizations, and hobby clubs (respondents indicated whether they were members of each type). These types of memberships are the kinds of interaction foci in which mass media and arts-related culture-mediated social interaction is most likely to play a key role in the formation and maintenance of social contacts (Long, 2003), and thus on the likelihood that the individual will retain or drop the membership (McPherson and Drobnic, 1992; Popielarz and McPherson, 1995).

2.1.3 Sociodemographic controls

The models include the following sociodemographic controls, measured consistently across the waves. *Gender* is a time-invariant binary indicator (1 = Women, 0 = Men). *Race* is a time-invariant binary indicator (1 = White, 0 = Non-White). *Age* is a time-varying continuous measure of the respondent’s age in years (ranging from 15 to 70+ in the baseline wave). *Education* is an ordinal measure capturing the respondent’s highest level of degree attainment across categories ranging from “Some high school” to “Post-graduate degree”; it was treated as a continuous variable to capture incremental status gains. *Employment status* is a time-varying binary indicator (1 = Employed, 0 = Not Employed). *Marital status* is a time-varying binary indicator (1 = Married, 0 = Not married/Divorced/Widowed). *Presence of children* is a time-varying binary indicator reflecting whether children currently live in the respondent’s household (1 = Yes, 0 = No). Finally, *City size* (Big City) is a time-varying binary indicator for whether the respondent lives in a major metropolitan area with a population over 100,000 (1 = Yes, 0 = No). The descriptive statistics for these variables are detailed in the Appendix (Table 2).

2.2 Longitudinal Culture conversion model

2.2.1 Analytic Strategy

In this section, I estimate the potential causal effect of cultural capital (as measured by taste diversity) on the maintenance of network connectivity over time. Estimating this reciprocal effect longitudinally presents two major methodological challenges: unobserved individual heterogeneity (time-invariant individual-level factors correlated with both variables) and simultaneity bias. To deal with these issues and properly model count-based network outcomes, I present a unified longitudinal modeling framework.

I use a Mundlak (within-between) specification in a mixed-effects modeling framework (Mundlak, 1978). Standard random-effects models require the stringent assumption that unobserved individual-level heterogeneity is entirely uncorrelated with the regressors. The Mundlak approach relaxes this assumption by explicitly including the person-specific longitudinal means (the "between" effect) of the time-varying covariates alongside the group-mean-centered deviations (the "within" effect). This allows us to cleanly disentangle the "within-person" effect (how temporary changes in an individual's cultural taste over time affect changes in their social connectivity) from the "between-person" effect (how stable, average differences in cultural tastes between individuals relate to average differences in social connectivity), thereby minimizing omitted variable bias.

Furthermore, because the two sets of primary outcome variables for social connectivity have different distributional properties, I use appropriate generalized linear mixed models for each. The frequency of interaction with friends and kin is an ordinal variable with three levels (Seldom/Never, Sometimes, Very Often) and is therefore estimated using a mixed-effects cumulative link (ordered logit) model. The number of voluntary association memberships is a discrete, non-negative integer count, and is estimated using a Poisson regression. This ensures that the estimates correctly respect the variance and distributional structure of the data.

3 Results

The culture conversion model (Lizardo, 2006; Lewis and Kaufman, 2018; Joseph et al., 2014; Jæger and Meuleman, 2026) implies that individuals who have command of a wide variety of tastes will be able to sustain larger and sparser personal networks over time, allowing them to reap the benefits of those social connections in the form of higher than average rates of social interaction and a higher ability to remain connected to important social foci where new

Table 1: Mundlak Mixed-Effects Models for Network Connectivity (1985-1995)

	Friends	Kin	Org. Mem.
Cultural Breadth (Within)	0.297**	0.229**	0.046
Education (Within)	0.081	0.202	0.053
Married (Within)	−0.507	0.855	−0.323
Children (Within)	0.131	0.269	−0.080
Big City (Within)	−0.592	−0.922	−0.102
Employed (Within)	−0.301	−0.192	0.037
Age (Within)	0.021	−0.026	0.001
Cultural Breadth (Between)	0.479**	0.215**	0.191**
Education (Between)	0.028	0.205*	0.087**
Married (Between)	−0.224	1.356**	0.168
Children (Between)	−0.044	0.089	−0.002
Big City (Between)	−0.207	0.093	−0.059
Employed (Between)	−0.648*	0.028	−0.051
Age (Between)	0.013+	−0.037**	0.004
Women	−0.699**	−0.468+	0.290**
White	−0.271	−0.347	0.344
Num. Observations	1509	1509	1509
Between-Person Variance	1.29	1.77	0.31
ICC (Between-Person Prop.)	0.28	0.35	

Wave fixed effects and threshold coefficients omitted for space.

SEs omitted for space.

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01

Within-person variance for count/ordinal models is fixed by their theoretical link functions.

contacts are made and old ones are sustained. The results of the Mundlak (within-between) mixed-effects models of the effect of cultural capital (in the form of "omnivore" taste breadth) on network outcomes across time periods are presented in Table 1.

Consistent with the culture conversion model, the between-person differences (the person-mean effects) demonstrate the durable power of cultural capital across all three relational domains (see Table 1 and Figure 1). Persons who display a persistently wide variety of tastes (a higher longitudinal mean of cultural breadth) sustain significantly higher frequencies of informal social interaction with elective ties, specifically friends ($\beta \approx 0.48, p < 0.05$). Beyond these elective network ties, average cultural breadth also has a significant, positive effect on the frequency of interacting with structurally prescribed family members ($\beta \approx 0.22, p < 0.05$), though the magnitude of this effect is roughly half that observed for friends. Finally, possessing a high average repertoire of tastes significantly raises the chances of remaining structurally integrated into important

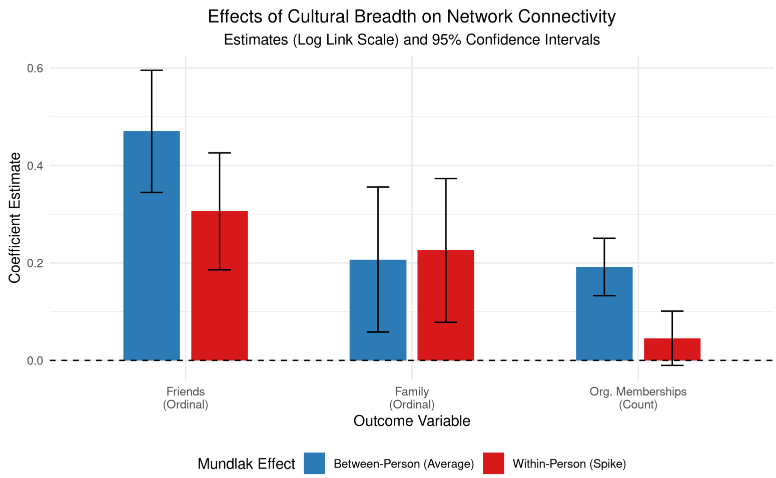

Figure 1: Effects of Cultural Breadth on Network Connectivity (Estimates on Log Link Scale and 95% CIs).

social foci of interaction, such as voluntary organizations ($\beta \approx 0.19, p < 0.05$). This structural integration effect aligns with the idea that retaining memberships is largely a matter of keeping alive the network ties that bind an individual to an organization (Popielarz and McPherson, 1995). While this cross-sectional "between" effect does not offer definitive evidence of strict causality, it firmly embeds prior cross-sectional findings (Lizardo, 2006; Cebula, 2023; Jæger and Meuleman, 2026) in a rigorous longitudinal modeling framework.

The Mundlak specification also allows us to evaluate the *within*-person effects—whether a temporary spike in an individual's cultural tastes over their own average translates to immediate gains in connectivity. These effects come closer to capturing any causal effects that gains or losses in cultural capital have on network ties. Here, the dynamics differ markedly by tie type, as visualized in Figure 1. Temporary expansions in cultural repertoires yield significant immediate boosts to informal socializing for both friends ($\beta \approx 0.30, p < 0.05$) and family ($\beta \approx 0.23, p < 0.05$), consistent with a culture-conversion imagery. However, for structural integration into voluntary organizations, the within-person effect is not significant ($p > 0.05$). This suggests that while temporary spikes in cultural engagement immediately boost fluid, informal socializing, it is the durable, trait-like possession of cultural capital (the stable between-person difference) that is strictly required to sustain structural integration into formal organizations. Taken together, these differential effect sizes underscore that cultural capital operates on dual tracks: it serves as an essential, immediate engine for navigating fluid interpersonal interactions, while its long-term accumulation acts as a stabilizing structural filter.

4 Discussion and Conclusion

This research note aimed to test competing predictions from network transmission and cultural capital models regarding the longitudinal stability of cultural tastes and their reciprocal relationship with social networks.

The Mundlak mixed-effects models provide strong, nuanced evidence consistent with the culture conversion model (Lizardo, 2006). Looking across the three primary forms of connectivity (friends, family, and formal organizations), stable differences in cultural taste breadth significantly predict the maintenance of ties over time. Both elective (friends) and prescribed (family) informal ties, as well as structural integration into formal organizations, benefit from the durable, trait-like possession of cultural capital.

Crucially, however, the within-person effects reveal a dual-track dynamic. Temporary spikes in an individual's cultural repertoire yield significant immediate boosts to fluid, informal socializing with both friends and family. In contrast, temporary expansions in cultural taste provide no immediate benefit for structural integration into formal organizations. Navigating the formalized structures of organizational life appears to rely exclusively on long-term, stable possession of cultural capital, rather than fleeting bursts of engagement.

These findings point toward a decisive advantage for the cultural capital model over the network transmission framework. Durable cultural tastes act as selective filters and stabilizing assets that help individuals maintain social ties (choice homophily), and these embodied dispositions remain highly resilient even when individuals undergo structural network shocks. This aligns with recent work demonstrating that "cultural talk" and shared highbrow participation serve as fundamental mechanisms for enhancing network stability and quality over time (Jæger and Meuleman, 2026; Meuleman and Jæger, 2023). Furthermore, finding that cultural capital aids not just elective friendships but also prescribed family ties highlights its broad utility as a conversational and interactional resource in modern societies. By acting as structural opportunities for positive social exchange (Vanzella-Yang and Abrutyn, 2022), deep cultural repertoires allow individuals to navigate the inevitable network churn driven by life-course transitions without suffering a collapse in overall sociability (Lin and Marin, 2022; Weiss et al., 2022).

A limitation of this study is the reliance on proxy measures for network size (frequency of interaction and organizational memberships) rather than full ego-network data. Future research should utilize more granular, multi-wave personal network generators (e.g., Hollstein, 2023; Vacchiano et al., 2024) alongside detailed cultural consumption diaries to further untangle the micro-dynamics of how cultural capital sustains specific dyadic ties during life-course transitions.

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Appendix

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics of Variables Used in the Analysis

Numeric Variables	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Frequency of Interaction with Friends	1.85	0.79	1	3
Frequency of Interaction with Family	1.50	1.11	0	9
Voluntary Organization Memberships	0.79	0.91	0	4
Cultural Taste Breadth	5.34	2.04	0	10
Age	53.56	16.34	0	88
Education	2.81	1.36	0	6
Categorical Variables (Binary)	% (Mean $\times$ 100)			
Women	61.6%			
White	97.3%			
Married	74.0%			
Big City Resident	54.4%			
Employed	66.9%			